

AP PHOTO



THE CRASH

Turbulent Questions

Do competent helicopter flight crew put their foot down in adverse flying conditions or take a risk, prodded on by the politicians they ferry? This question assumes significance in light of the use of the ageing twin-engine six-seater Bell 430 helicopter, which was pulled out of the hangar for Rajasekhara Reddy on a wet morning at Hyderabad's Begumpet airport. The aviation forecast for six hours beginning 6.30 a.m. indicated the presence of dangerous cumulonimbus clouds along the flight path. These clouds are dangerous because they cause thunderstorms and lightning which can affect avionics on board and reduce visibility. Yet, Reddy seems to have been determined to reach Chittoor to resume his popular direct rural connect programme and attend a marriage ceremony of the son of a MLC. His desire not to miss the event may have pushed him to instruct the crew to carry on flying through the adverse weather. The crash is similar to the manner in which the then Lok Sabha Speaker GMC Balayogi died when the chopper he was travelling in under adverse weather conditions lost height, hit coconut palms and killed all on board. But that has not deterred politicians, particularly at poll time, to stretch themselves along with the crew as well as ageing and poorly-maintained aircraft.

Worse still, the emergency position indicating radio beacon system and other emergency and survival needs, including a satellite phone which is also fitted with a distress radio beam, were either not on board or malfunctioned. The Bell 430 was bought from the US manufacturers for Rs 26 crore in 1998. It is after problems and constraints, including the lack of a night landing facility, which led to force landings and repairs of the Bell chopper several times in recent years, that the Andhra Pradesh Aviation Corporation, at the behest of Reddy, acquired the spacious 16-seat Augusta Westland AW-139 helicopter for Rs 58 crore last year. As it was grounded for inspection, Reddy plumped for the Bell 430 in his race against time. He lost.

HOW THE CHOPPER STRAYED OFF COURSE, WHY NONE OF THE EMERGENCY SYSTEMS WORKED AND THE DAMAGE DONE RAISE SAFETY ISSUES.

THE AGEING BELL 430 WAS USED FOR THE FLIGHT BECAUSE THE NEWER CHOPPER WAS UNDER INSPECTION

sition to his authority. He may have used the many tricks in the trade to humble his political opponents but YSR will be remembered most for what he has done to revive a slack Congress in the state and for the welfare of its poor.

Now it is an uphill task for the party to find a suitable successor. With a larger number of younger activists, almost half the 156 are first-time legislators, there is little chance of a power struggle or a replay of the faction fights for leadership witnessed in the past. An option before the party is to persuade state Finance Minister K. Rosaiah, who has been made caretaker chief minister, to take charge given his seniority and statesmanlike approach to issues. It can deter the rebellious. The added advantage is that as the finance minister, and as a member of several Congress ministries earlier, Rosaiah is well-versed in macro aspects of governance, though he is far from aggressive. What he can do, though, is placate disgruntled elements easily.

An apprehension is that the Telangana issue may begin to simmer. This thought may make the party consider the name of the Union Urban Development Minister S. Jaipal Reddy from the region. The other thought is about steering the party in 2014, which neither Rosaiah nor Jaipal will be able to do with alacrity. Viewed in that context, the Congress may pick one of them for now and make another change mid-term for a younger leader. Sadly, none of the aspirants have comparable political acumen as that of YSR. If it is not handled deftly, the rival Telugu Desam Party will lose no time in accusing the Congress of poor governance by choosing chief ministers from Delhi. For the Reddy family, including his politician son Jagannathan Reddy, who owns a multi-edition Telugu daily and a TV channel, it will be an insurmountable loss. For the Congress, equally so. ■